

Who Got to Roar

The Roaring Twenties · 1920–1929 | Standards US.28, US.29, US.30, US.31, US.32, US.33, US.34, US.35, US.36, US.37, US.38

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

The 1920s are remembered as one long party — jazz, cars, radio, and easy money. But a decade can roar for some people while it slams the door on others. Who actually got to roar in the Twenties, who got shut out, and was a country changing this fast becoming freer — or just louder?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

Great Migration	The movement of millions of African Americans out of the rural South to Northern and Western cities (roughly 1916–1970).	Harlem Renaissance	A 1920s flowering of Black literature, art, and music centered in Harlem, New York.
mass culture	Shared entertainment and information — radio, movies, records — experienced by millions of people at once.	flapper	A 1920s young woman who broke with Victorian rules through new fashion, behavior, and independence.
fundamentalism vs. modernism	The 1920s clash between literal biblical belief and modern science and culture — dramatized by the Scopes Trial.	Prohibition	The nationwide ban on making and selling alcohol (1920–1933) under the 18th Amendment.
buying on margin	Buying stocks with mostly borrowed money, betting prices will keep rising.	nativism	Favoring native-born citizens and opposing immigrants — a powerful force behind 1920s immigration limits.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze the causes and effects of the Great Migration, and how it fed the Harlem Renaissance's celebration of Black identity. Notice: Imagine leaving the only home you've ever known — not for a vacation, but because staying could get you killed. You pack one suitcase, board a... Debrief: Explain the Great Migration using push and pull factors, then explain how it connected to the Harlem Renaissance. Use one piece of evidence (a source or figure) from the spread.	Push factors: Jim Crow segregation, racial violence, disenfranchisement, and poverty in the South. Pull factors: industrial jobs, higher wages, and greater freedom in Northern/Western cities. The Migration concentrated Black Americans in cities like Harlem, fueling the Harlem Renaissance — a flowering of Black art and music (e.g., Langston Hughes's 'I, Too,' Louis Armstrong's jazz) that celebrated Black identity. Strong answers cite a specific figure or source.
2	Explain how radio spread American music nationwide, making Nashville the capital of country music and carrying the blues into the mainstream. Notice: Your favorite song right now — how did you find it? A stream, an algorithm, a phone. Now erase all of that. In 1925 a brand-new machine did... Debrief: Explain how radio changed American music in the 1920s, and give one example each of how it spread country music and the blues. Why is Tennessee central to this story?	Radio let millions hear the same music simultaneously, spreading regional styles nationwide. Country: WSM's Grand Ole Opry (1925) made Nashville the country-music capital. Blues: Bessie Smith's millions of record sales (with roots in W.C. Handy's Memphis) carried the blues mainstream. Tennessee is central because Nashville (Opry/country) and Memphis (Beale Street/blues) were both hearths of this music.
3	Analyze how radio and film, new technologies (aviation, electricity), and Ford's assembly line created a modern mass-consumer society. Notice: One man flies alone across an entire ocean, and by the time he lands, the whole planet already knows his name — because a new machine carried the... Debrief: Choose two of these — radio/film, aviation or electrification, or the automobile — and explain how each made American life more modern in the 1920s. Include one cost or trade-off.	Radio/film created mass culture (shared entertainment, celebrities like Lindbergh, national advertising). Electrification/appliances changed home life. The automobile (via Ford's assembly line) gave ordinary families mobility and created highways and suburbs. Trade-offs might include monotonous assembly-line work, unequal access to the new prosperity, or growing consumer debt. Strong answers pair a genuine change with an honest cost.
4	Analyze the changing roles and status of women in the 1920s — flappers, the birth-control movement, and the limits that remained. Notice: Cut your hair short. Wear what you want. Go out without asking permission. Get a job, spend your own money, and dance to music your grandmother... Debrief: Describe two ways women's lives changed in the 1920s and two limits that remained. Was the 'new woman' mostly real freedom or mostly hype? Defend your answer with evidence.	Changes: flapper fashion and social freedoms; more women working (about 1 in 4 by 1930); the vote (1920); the birth-control movement. Limits: about 60% of men's wages, job discrimination, expectation to quit at marriage, narrow 'women's jobs.' Strong answers take a defensible position weighing genuine new freedoms against persistent economic and social inequality.
5	Analyze the civil-liberties and civil-rights challenges of the 1920s — the Red Scare, the Klan's resurgence, the Tulsa massacre, and immigration... Notice: A country gets scared. Scared of radicals, scared of immigrants, scared of anyone who looks or prays or votes differently. And instead of talking... Debrief: Identify three examples of intolerance or civil-liberties violations in the 1920s, then explain how Americans organized to resist. Why might these events have been left out of the 'Roaring Twenties' story for so long?	Examples (any three): the Palmer Raids/Red Scare; the revived KKK; the 1921 Tulsa massacre; the 1924 National Origins Act. Resistance: the NAACP, Ida B. Wells-Barnett's anti-lynching work, and Marcus Garvey's UNIA. Strong answers note that the celebratory 'Roaring Twenties' image and the marginalization of victims' histories helped keep these events out of popular memory.
6	Analyze Prohibition — its goals, its unintended consequences (organized crime), and its ultimate failure and repeal. Notice: What happens when you make something illegal that millions of people refuse to stop wanting? You don't end it — you just hand the whole business... Debrief: Explain why many Americans supported Prohibition, then explain its main unintended consequences and why it was repealed. What general lesson does Prohibition teach about laws?	Supporters (temperance and church movements) believed banning alcohol would reduce poverty, family harm, and crime. Unintended consequences: a massive illegal industry — bootlegging, speakeasies, and organized crime (e.g., Al Capone). It was nearly unenforceable and was repealed by the 21st Amendment (1933). Lesson: passing a law does not automatically change behavior, especially when it conflicts with what large numbers of people want to do.
7	Analyze the Scopes Trial as a dramatization of the clash between fundamentalism and modernism — staged in Dayton, Tennessee. Notice: A small Tennessee town. A young teacher. A law that makes it a crime to teach where humans came from. In the summer of 1925, the whole country —... Debrief: Explain what the Scopes Trial was about and why it mattered beyond one teacher. Represent both Bryan's and Darrow's positions fairly, then explain why historians say 'no one really won.'	Scopes was tried under Tennessee's Butler Act for teaching evolution. It mattered because it dramatized the national clash between fundamentalism (Bryan: literal Bible, protecting tradition) and modernism (Darrow: modern science and academic freedom). 'No one really won' because Scopes was convicted (a legal win for fundamentalists) while national press coverage made fundamentalism look outdated (a cultural win for modernists) — the underlying divide remained. Strong answers steelman both sides.
8	Analyze the economic weaknesses of the 1920s — easy credit, stock speculation, and inequality — that set up the Great Depression. Notice: Buy it now, pay later. Put ten percent down and borrow the rest. Everyone's getting rich in the stock market, so throw your money in — prices only...	Credit: installment 'buy now, pay later' buying left consumers and businesses deep in debt. Speculation: buying stocks on margin (mostly borrowed money) meant falling prices would trigger cascading debt. Inequality: wealth concentrated at the top while farmers/workers were left out, weakening overall demand. Together

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
	Debrief: Explain three economic weaknesses of the 1920s (credit, speculation, inequality) and how each helped set up the Great Depression. Which do you think was most dangerous, and why?	they made the economy fragile, and it collapsed in 1929. Strong answers defend a choice of the 'most dangerous' with reasoning.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 4 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **An African American family of nine, dressed in coats and hats with their suitcases at their feet, photographed shortly after arriving in Chicago during the Great Migration, when hundreds of thousands of Black Americans moved from the rural South to northern cities.**²⁸ on the Great Migration.

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *This is a real family, photographed just after arriving in Chicago from the South around 1920 — coats on, suitcases at their feet. Ask: what can...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.28/33. Keep the Migration honest about Northern hardship; keep the Renaissance joyful and central. Real people (Hughes, Hurston, Armstrong) appear via cited photos/texts only. TN anchor: Memphis/Beale/Handy.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1920	Prohibition begins (18th Amendment)	Mixed Historians read Prohibition as a genuinely mixed experiment — sincere reform goals and some reduced consumption against enormous unintended costs...
1921	Tulsa Race Massacre	Setback Broadly recognized as one of the worst incidents of racial violence in U.S. history — an unambiguous setback for justice.
1924	National Origins Act restricts immigration	Setback Widely treated as a nativist, racially motivated narrowing of the nation's openness to newcomers — a setback for the country's founding openness.
1925	The Great Migration and Harlem Renaissance	Climb Broadly celebrated as a landmark flowering of Black identity and a step toward fuller participation in national life — a clear advance on the...
1925	The Grand Ole Opry puts Nashville on the map	Climb Regarded as a founding moment of country music and 1920s mass culture — a genuine cultural advance, if a modest one on the union's yardstick.
1925	The Scopes Trial	Mixed Genuinely contested — fundamentalists won the verdict while modernists won much of public opinion — so historians read it as a cultural draw and...
1929	The credit boom crests	Mixed The decade's growth was real but unevenly shared and financed by unsustainable credit and speculation, so its health is debated and it is marked...

B Debrief & Closing Argument

The Twenties are the trickiest decade yet for the 'more perfect union' question, because progress and backlash happen at the exact same time. The...

Closing question: The 1920s advanced some Americans and set others back — often in the very same year. Pick two events from this unit that pulled the country in opposite directions, and use them to argue whether the decade, on balance, moved the United States closer to its founding promise or further from it. Cite the unit. There's no answer key — make the case.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.